Marsupials in America and Australia

Marsupials are nonplacental mammals whose young complete their gestation feeding from their mother's teats, typically in a pouch on the belly. Now found only in the Americas (mainly South and Central) and Australia, they are thought to have evolved in North America 100 million years ago. They spread to South America and diversified into many different species.

Several groups later moved into what is now Antarctica and on into southern Australia. It is thought that they traveled via a belt of vegetation straddling the three areas, which were once all part of the southern landmass called Gondwana.

By 55 million years ago, the continents had separated, and marsupial species began to evolve differently. The only known Antarctic marsupial fossils, found on Seymour Island in 40-million-year-old rocks, resemble South American marsupials of the same period, but not those of Australia.